He was prepared to make military interventions as he did in a civil war in Sri Lanka.

When Zheng He was making his voyages, there already existed a number of Chinese settlements in South East Asia but the Majapahit empire of Java was the most powerful in the region. [36] Indeed, a century earlier, the Javans had militarily beaten back Chinese–Mongol attempts to establish control in the region. In 1378, the Ming emperor had sent envoys to try and instal his candidate on the Srivijaya throne. The Majapahit had, not surprisingly, seen this as interference in their sphere of influence and had killed the envoys. [37]

Zheng He would have been aware of this history. The Chinese admiral, therefore, decided to create a counterweight by supporting Parmeswara's nascent kingdom in Melaka. A large Chinese settlement was created in Melaka and Parmeswara personally visited the Ming court. Most interestingly, the Chinese encouraged the Melakans to convert to Islam. Zheng He and many of his commanders were Muslims, but this policy is unlikely to have been driven merely by religious zeal. By most indications, Zheng He had a pragmatic view of religion. It is probable that Chinese support of Islam in South East Asia was more of a geo-political strategy to create a counterweight to the Hindus of Java.

It is even possible that the Chinese wanted to diminish the outside risk of an Indian revival re-exerting its influence on the region. The Chinese of this period were very conscious of themselves as a civilizational nation and wanted to establish themselves as the civilizational top dog. In any event, the Chinese strategy set in motion the steady Islamization of South East Asia. [38] Melaka boomed while the Majapahit slowly withdrew till the last of the Majapahit princes sought refuge in the small island of Bali, where their descendants have kept alive their culture. The network of Chinese merchants survived European colonization and they are still an important part of business in the region.

The Chinese domination of the seas, however, came to an abrupt end. The mandarins decided that the voyages were not worth the expense. The